

Windows Batch Files for R

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Introduction

This document describes a number of Windows batch, javascript and `.hta` files that may be used in conjunction with R. Each is self contained and independent of the others. None requires installation - just place on the Windows path or in current directory.¹

`R.bat` is used to run R without permanently modifying the Windows registry. It can also be useful on systems with restricted access to the registry. To configure it simply modify the `set R_HOME` line near the top to point to the current version of R you wish to use.

`movedir.bat` and `copydir.bat` are used for moving or copying packages from one library to another such as when R is upgraded to a new version. There is nothing specific to R in these. They simply move or copy the files from one directory to another. I don't use these any more since I find that I collect numerous packages that I no longer use and prefer to start with a fresh slate on each new version of R.

`el.js` runs its arguments in elevated mode (i.e. with Administrator privileges).

`clip2r.js` copies the current clipboard into a running R instance. It can be used with `vim` or other text editor.

R.bat

Purpose

The purpose of `R.bat` is to facilitate the use of R from the Windows `cmd` line by eliminating the need to make any registry changes.

Typical Usage

Typical usage of `R.bat` to launch R gui is the following²:

¹To display the Windows path enter `path` without arguments at the Windows `cmd` line. To display the path to the current directory enter `cd` without arguments at the Windows `cmd` line.

²If `R.exe` were on the Windows path and before `R.bat` then it would have to be written as follows: `R.bat gui`

R gui

This runs Rgui.exe. If further arguments are specified they are passed on to Rgui.exe. For example,

R gui --help

will run:

Rgui.exe --help

Subcommands

Running

R help

will show usage information. The first argument is a subcommand so R gui starts the R gui, R dir lists the directories in the R directory (one for each version of R you have installed), R cd changes to the R directory, R show shows the environment variable blues that R.bat is using (as well as any other environment variables that begin with R).

> R help

Usage: help [command] [args...]

Core R Executables (Default is 'r'):

r	- Runs R.exe console
gui	- Spawns Rgui.exe
cmd	- Runs Rcmd.exe
term	- Runs Rterm.exe
script	- Runs Rscript.exe
setreg	- Runs RSetReg.exe

Tcl/Tk Shells (Dynamic Version Discovery):

tclsh	- Runs internal tclsh*.exe
wish	- Spawns internal wish*.exe GUI

Utilities:

cd	- Opens a command prompt at the parent directory (C:\Program Files\R)
dir	- Lists files in the parent directory
show	- Displays active environment variables starting with 'R'
help	- Displays this help details

Selecting R Version

If you have multiple versions of R that you want to access at the same time make a copy of R.bat with a new name and set the `set R_HOME` line to that version of R.

el.js

`el.js` runs its arguments elevated (i.e. with Administrator privileges). For example,

```
el R touch
```

The user will be prompted to allow elevation to proceed.

clip2r.js

This program writes the clipboard into the running R session. It can be used with `vim` or other editor. See the source for additional instructions.

make-batchfiles-pdf.bat

This batch file creates a pdf of this documentation from the markdown file `batchfiles.md`. `pandoc` must be installed for this to run. It is run without arguments:

```
make-batchfiles-pdf
```